ViBridge-VQA: Bridging Global and Local Visual Tokens for Parameter-Efficient Vietnamese Visual Question Answering

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Abstract. Vision–language models (VLMs) such as Vintern-1B have brought strong multimodal abilities to Vietnamese, but adapting them to a new Visual Question Answering (VQA) benchmark remains costly: the usual recipe fine-tunes the language model on many high-resolution image tiles, while task-specific architectures must be trained from scratch. In this paper, we propose **ViBridge-VQA**, a parameter-efficient approach that improves Vintern-1B without updating any of its pre-trained weights. ViBridge-VQA feeds the frozen language decoder two complementary kinds of visual tokens from a single image view: *global* tokens, produced by a small trainable bridge from the `[CLS]` vector that Vintern-1B discards, and *local* tokens, produced by Vintern-1B's own pre-aligned projector and pooled to a chosen budget. We treat the number of tokens as an accuracy–cost trade-off and select it on validation data as the knee of the Pareto front. On the reasoning-oriented AutoViVQA benchmark, the selected budget of 50 visual tokens gives two main results. Training only the bridge (1.35% of the parameters) raises the F1 of Vintern-1B from 17.6 to 54.6, comparable to the published F1 of the fine-tuned Vintern-1B (53.8), whose decoder reads 1,792 visual tokens per image, 36 times more than ours. Training a lightweight decoder LoRA together with the bridge (1.57% of the parameters) raises F1 further to 58.2. At a fixed number of global tokens, adding local tokens improves F1 far more than increasing the global tokens from 8 to 14, and on four other Vietnamese VQA datasets the model with local tokens outperforms a global-only model with a decoder LoRA.

Keywords: Vietnamese Visual Question Answering · Vision–Language Models · Parameter-Efficient Learning · Visual Token Budget · Generative VQA

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1 Introduction

Visual Question Answering (VQA) asks a model to answer a natural-language question about an image. The task has progressed rapidly with large vision–language models (VLMs) such as BLIP-2 [12], Flamingo [1] and LLaVA [19], which connect a pre-trained vision encoder to a pre-trained language model and generate free-form answers. Vietnamese has followed this trend: Vintern-1B [7] connects an InternViT-300M encoder [6] to a Qwen2.5-0.5B decoder [27] and is an open Vietnamese VLM, while benchmarks such as ViVQA [30], OpenViVQA [22] and the recent reasoning-oriented AutoViVQA [21] make it possible to measure progress in this low-resource setting.

Obtaining a strong model on a new Vietnamese benchmark, however, is still expensive. The common recipe fine-tunes an existing VLM: the fine-tuned Vintern-1B baseline of AutoViVQA adds LoRA adapters to the language model and splits every image into up to six high-resolution tiles plus a thumbnail, so that the decoder reads up to 1,792 visual tokens per image. The alternative is to design a task-specific architecture, as ViMoE-VQA [20] does with a sparse mixture-of-experts fusion module and a decoder trained on AutoViVQA. A cheaper option is to keep the whole VLM frozen and train only a small connector between its encoder and decoder. Existing connectors follow two designs, each with its own weakness. A *global-only bridge* maps the global image vector to a few tokens; it is cheap, but it loses local details such as small objects, printed text and spatial relations. A *learned patch compressor*, such as a Q-Former, keeps these details, but it has to learn a new mapping from visual features to the decoder, which is difficult with limited Vietnamese data.

Vintern-1B suggests a third option. Its projector was pre-trained to map image regions into the input space of the decoder, so this alignment already exists and does not need to be learned again. At the same time, the model discards the global `[CLS]` vector of its encoder, which summarises the whole scene. This raises our research question: *when labelled data is limited, is reusing the pre-trained visual alignment of a VLM, with pooling to control the number of tokens, more effective than learning a new connector, and how many global and local tokens does the frozen decoder need?*

To address this question, we propose **ViBridge-VQA**, which gives the frozen decoder of Vintern-1B two complementary kinds of visual tokens from a single image view. *Local* tokens reuse the frozen projector of Vintern-1B, average-pooled to a chosen budget and placed in its original image slot, so the decoder receives region features in the representation it was trained to read. *Global* tokens are produced from the `[CLS]` vector by a small trainable bridge and add the scene-level information that Vintern-1B ignores. Only this bridge is trained. Because every additional token increases inference cost, we treat the number of global and local tokens as a budget and select it as the knee of the accuracy–cost Pareto front. As a result, ViBridge-VQA with 14 global and 36 local tokens reaches an F1 comparable to the published fine-tuned Vintern-1B while its decoder reads 36 times fewer visual tokens and none of its weights is updated.

In summary, our main contributions are as follows:

- We propose **ViBridge-VQA**, a global–local bridge that improves a frozen Vietnamese VLM by combining trainable global tokens with local tokens from its own pre-trained projector. With 50 visual tokens, it raises the F1 of Vintern-1B on AutoViVQA from 17.6 (zero-shot) to 54.6 when only the bridge is trained (1.35% of the parameters), and to 58.2 when a lightweight decoder LoRA is trained with it (1.57%).
- We study the **visual token budget** systematically over eight configurations and three random seeds, and select it on the validation split as the knee of the accuracy–cost Pareto front. The choice is the same for every metric and for cost measured in tokens or in runtime.
- We **analyse where the gains come from**: adding local tokens improves F1 far more than increasing the global tokens from 8 to 14, local tokens from the pre-trained projector work better than a learned compressor, they complement decoder adaptation, and they improve results on four other Vietnamese VQA datasets.

2 Related Work

Early VQA systems classified over a fixed set of answers, whereas current generative VLMs produce free-form answers with an autoregressive language model [12,1,19]. Vietnamese datasets include ViVQA [30], OpenViVQA [22], ViCLEVR [32], ViOCRVQA [26] and ViTextVQA [24]. AutoViVQA [21] contributes 37,077 questions on 19,411 COCO images [17], generated by large language models, filtered by an ensemble of validators and annotated with reasoning categories, with an emphasis on relational, causal and multi-step reasoning. On the modelling side, BARTPhoBEiT [31] and AViVQA-TranConI [23] combine pre-trained visual and Vietnamese language representations, Vintern-1B [7] brings an instruction-tuned VLM to Vietnamese, and ViMoE-VQA [20] routes multimodal tokens to sparse experts for generative VQA on AutoViVQA. AutoViVQA and ViMoE-VQA are earlier work of our group; here we use the AutoViVQA data but no component of ViMoE-VQA, and the method, the image-disjoint split and all our results are new. These approaches either train a new model or fine-tune an existing VLM on multi-tile inputs; in contrast, we keep every pre-trained weight of Vintern-1B frozen and use a single image view.

Keeping the vision encoder and the language model frozen and training only a connector is a common way to build VLMs efficiently, and connectors differ mainly in what they must learn. Frozen [33] learns a visual prefix from a global image representation. The Q-Former of BLIP-2 [12] learns a set of queries that compress the patch features, which preserves details but requires a large module (188M parameters) pre-trained on millions of image–text pairs. LLaVA [19,18] projects every patch token with a small MLP, which preserves locality but passes hundreds of tokens to the decoder; Honeybee [4] proposes locality-preserving abstractors, and InternVL [6], on which Vintern-1B is built, merges neighbouring patches before its MLP projector. In all of these models, the mapping from patches to the decoder is learned during large-scale pre-training. ViBridge-VQA

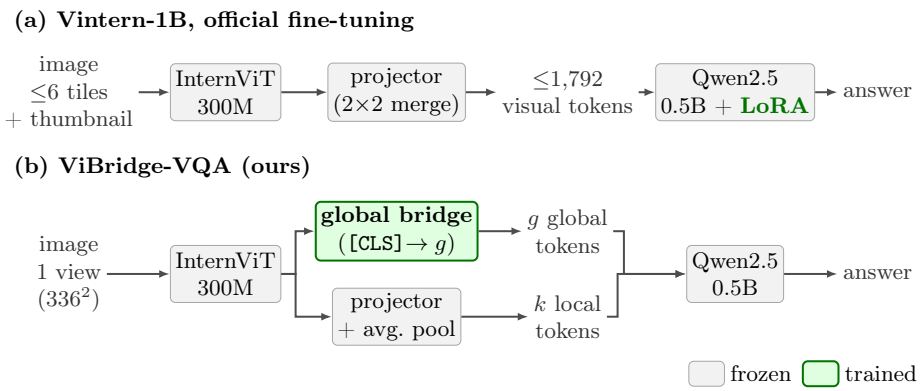


Fig. 1: Overview of ViBridge-VQA compared with the official fine-tuning of Vintern-1B. (a) The official recipe encodes up to seven views and adapts the decoder with LoRA. (b) ViBridge-VQA encodes one view; a trainable bridge maps the `[CLS]` vector to g global tokens, and the frozen projector gives k pooled local tokens (selected: $g = 14$, $k = 36$).

differs in two respects: it does not learn this local mapping again but reuses the projector already pre-trained in the VLM, and it trains only a small global bridge (12.9M parameters) on about 26k task questions.

The number of visual tokens largely determines the cost of the decoder. Inference-optimal scaling of VLMs [13] shows that a few tokens can suffice for many tasks, and Matryoshka multimodal models [3] train a model to work at several nested pooled token budgets and show that the required budget depends on the task. Other work reduces the visual tokens directly: DeCo [35] replaces the Q-Former with adaptive average pooling of the patch tokens and reports better results, TokenPacker [14] learns a compact projector, and LLaVA-PruMerge [29] and FastV [5] prune or merge visual tokens of an existing model. Like DeCo, we rely on simple average pooling, but we apply it to the output of a projector that is already pre-trained, keep the whole VLM frozen, and choose among budgets with explicit criteria, namely the knee of the Pareto front [28] and TOPSIS [11]. Parameter-efficient methods such as adapters [9], prefix tuning [15] and LoRA [10] reduce the cost of adaptation from the other side, by training a small number of additional weights in the decoder. We use decoder LoRA both as a baseline and as a complement, and ask whether a small training budget is better spent on the visual tokens or on adapting the decoder.

3 Proposed Method

We formulate VQA as conditional answer generation: given an image I and a Vietnamese question q, the model generates a short free-form answer $y = (y_1, \ldots, y_T)$. ViBridge-VQA builds on Vintern-1B [7] and keeps all of its pre-trained weights frozen. Instead of adapting the model, it changes what the decoder sees.

3.1 Overall Architecture

As illustrated in Fig. 1, ViBridge-VQA keeps the three components of Vintern-1B: the InternViT-300M vision encoder (24 layers, width 1024), its two-layer MLP projector P, and the Qwen2.5-0.5B-Instruct language decoder (24 layers, width 896). Each image is resized to one 336×336 view (24×24 patches of 14×14 pixels); InternViT, pre-trained at 448×448, bicubically interpolates its position embeddings to this resolution. The encoder returns one vector per patch and a global `[CLS]` vector $v \in \mathbb{R}^{1024}$. Vintern-1B uses only the patch vectors: it merges every 2×2 block of neighbouring patches into one 4096-dimensional vector (pixel shuffle) and maps each merged vector into the decoder input space with P, which was pre-trained to align the two backbones. At our resolution this yields a 12×12 grid of 144 region tokens. ViBridge-VQA uses both outputs of the encoder.

3.2 Global Tokens

The `[CLS]` vector summarises the whole scene, but Vintern-1B never passes it to the decoder. A small trainable bridge g_ϕ expands it into g tokens with two linear heads:

$$g_\phi(v) = \left[\, W_a v + b_a;\ \mathrm{reshape}_{(g-1)\times 896}(W_e v + b_e) \,\right] \in \mathbb{R}^{g \times 896}. \tag{1}$$

where $W_a \in \mathbb{R}^{896\times 1024}$ and $W_e \in \mathbb{R}^{(g-1)896\times 1024}$. The first head produces an *anchor* token, and the second produces $g-1$ complementary tokens that present the global content to the decoder from different learned directions. The bridge has $1025 \cdot 896 \cdot g$ parameters, i.e., 12,857,600 for $g = 14$, and its g tokens are placed before the prompt. We consider $g \in \{8, 14\}$: $g = 8$ is our global-only model, and $g = 14$ gave the highest F1 when the global-only bridge was varied from 4 to 20 tokens (Section 4.5). The final pair (g, k) is selected with the criterion of Section 3.5.

3.3 Local Tokens

To give the decoder region-level detail, ViBridge-VQA also passes local tokens, taken directly from the 144 region tokens of the frozen projector P. To control their number, we average-pool the 12×12 grid to an $s \times s$ grid, so that $k = s^2$ with $s \in \{1, 3, 6, 12\}$: $k = 144$ keeps every region token, and $k = 36$ averages each 2×2 block. The pooled tokens replace the embeddings of k image-context placeholders inside Vintern-1B's own image slot, `<img>` $\cdots$ `</img>`, in the prompt. Because they come from the pre-trained projector rather than from a newly learned projection of the patches, the local tokens stay in the representation that the decoder was trained to read, and no parameters are needed to produce them.

3.4 Training Objective

Only the bridge parameters ϕ are trained; the vision encoder, the projector and the decoder remain frozen, and no adapter is added to the decoder. We minimise

the cross-entropy of the answer tokens:

$$\mathcal{L} = -\sum_{t=1}^{T} \log p\big(y_t \mid y_{<t},\, g_\phi(v),\, \mathrm{pool}_s(P(x)),\, q\big), \tag{2}$$

where x denotes the merged patch vectors. ViBridge-VQA can also be combined with decoder adaptation: in that variant, a rank-16 LoRA [10] on the query, key, value and output projections of every decoder layer is trained jointly with the bridge, which adds 2,162,688 parameters. Throughout the paper, percentages of trained parameters are relative to all parameters of the model, i.e., the frozen components of Vintern-1B (about 0.94B, including the vision encoder, projector, embeddings and output layer) plus the trained modules. With $g = 14$, the bridge alone trains 12.86M parameters (1.35%), and the bridge with LoRA 15.02M (1.57%).

3.5 Choosing the Token Budget

The cost of the decoder grows with the number of visual tokens $g + k$, so we treat the pair (g, k) as a budget to be chosen. In our experiments, accuracy increases monotonically with the number of visual tokens, so every configuration lies on the accuracy–cost Pareto front and the front alone does not single one out. We therefore select its *knee* [28], the point after which additional tokens bring diminishing returns. After normalising cost c and accuracy a to $[0, 1]$ over the front, the knee is the configuration that maximises $\hat{a} - \hat{c}$, i.e., the one lying furthest above the line joining the cheapest and the most accurate configuration. The knee is computed on the validation split only, and we check the choice with the multi-criteria method TOPSIS [11], also on validation. Test results are computed for every configuration only to be reported; no choice is based on them.

4 Experiments

4.1 Dataset and Evaluation Metrics

Dataset. We evaluate on AutoViVQA [21], a Vietnamese VQA benchmark on MS COCO images [17] in which each question has five short free-form reference answers and a reasoning type. To measure answers about images the model has never seen, we use an image-disjoint split. After removing 273 duplicated (image, question) pairs and 97 questions without one of the eight reasoning labels, we partition the 36,707 questions by image into a 70/15/15 split (seed 42), so that no image appears in more than one split: 25,776 / 5,463 / 5,468 questions on 13,579 / 2,909 / 2,910 images. In a preliminary comparison, this split lowered the F1 of the global-only bridge by about 0.5 points relative to a split that does not group questions by image.

Evaluation metrics. Following AutoViVQA and ViMoE-VQA, we report exact-match Accuracy, word-level Precision, Recall and F1, BLEU [25], ROUGE-L [16], METEOR [2] and CIDEr [34], all against the five reference answers and multiplied by 100. All our models are scored with the same implementation.

4.2 Experimental Setup

Implementation details. The vision encoder, the projector and the decoder are initialised from Vintern-1B-v3.5 [7] and kept frozen. ViBridge-VQA is trained for two epochs, after which neither the validation loss nor CIDEr improves further; the variants with a decoder LoRA are trained for one epoch, and the global-only model with LoRA also for three epochs, its strongest setting (+1.3 validation F1). We use AdamW with a learning rate of 2×10^{-4} and an effective batch size of 8, train on the first reference answer, and decode greedily (batch size 2, at most 50 new tokens). Unless stated otherwise, every configuration is trained with three random seeds (42, 123 and 3407), and we report the mean and the standard deviation. Every model fits on a single 16 GB GPU such as an NVIDIA T4. The token budget is selected on the validation split, and the test split is used only for the final report.

Baselines. We compare against three groups of systems: (1) multimodal models fine-tuned on AutoViVQA, namely ViT5_ViT, BARTPhoBEiT [31], Vintern-1B and ViMoE-VQA [20]; (2) models used zero-shot, namely Vintern-1B, LLaMA 3.2, Gemini 2.0 and 2.5 Flash, and GPT-5; and (3) our *global-only* model, which uses the same bridge without local tokens ($k = 0$, $g = 8$), with and without a decoder LoRA. The results of groups (1) and (2) are those reported in the AutoViVQA and ViMoE-VQA papers. The fine-tuned Vintern-1B follows the official recipe: the vision encoder and the projector are frozen, a rank-16 LoRA adapts the language model for one epoch, and each image is encoded as up to six 448×448 tiles plus a thumbnail.

4.3 Main Results

Table 1 compares ViBridge-VQA with fine-tuned multimodal models and zero-shot language models. Without updating any weight of Vintern-1B, ViBridge-VQA raises its F1 from 17.55 to 54.56, a level comparable to the published fine-tuned Vintern-1B (53.76), while its decoder reads 50 instead of 1,792 visual tokens. Only its exact-match accuracy is lower (11.75 versus 13.01); with all 144 local tokens, it reaches the same level (13.19).

Decoder adaptation further improves these results. Training a rank-16 LoRA jointly with the bridge for one epoch raises F1 to 58.17 and gives the highest exact-match accuracy in Table 1. ViMoE-VQA, a task-specific model whose fusion module and decoder are trained on AutoViVQA, keeps the highest precision and F1, whereas ViBridge-VQA reuses an existing VLM and trains only 1.57% of its parameters. Compared with our global-only model, ViBridge-VQA with a frozen decoder already matches the global-only model trained with a three-epoch

Table 1: Performance on the AutoViVQA test set (×100). Baselines: results reported in AutoViVQA [21] and ViMoE-VQA [20] (ViMoE-VQA: mean of five seeds). Ours: ViBridge-VQA ($g = 14$, $k = 36$, 50 visual tokens) without and with a one-epoch decoder LoRA, image-disjoint split (Section 4.1), mean over three seeds, share of trained parameters in parentheses; standard deviations in Section 4.3. R-L: ROUGE-L, MET.: METEOR. Bold: best per column.

	Model	Acc	P	R	F1	BLEU	R-L	MET.	CIDEr
Fine-tuned	ViT5_ViT	7.97	46.84	50.33	48.52	4.13	46.89	31.02	72.68
	BARTPhoBEiT	8.81	45.30	46.48	45.88	4.33	44.83	24.57	**188.96**
	Vintern-1B	13.01	52.47	55.12	53.76	6.11	51.93	35.25	72.84
	ViMoE-VQA	9.55	**62.89**	58.60	**60.69**	12.54	47.12	39.10	88.76
Zero-shot	Vintern-1B	0.12	17.52	19.87	17.55	1.91	25.84	23.93	8.54
	LLaMA 3.2	0.36	23.96	73.71	36.16	3.62	36.11	30.01	62.84
	Gemini 2.0 F.	0.55	27.20	74.10	39.79	4.41	39.60	31.72	74.42
	Gemini 2.5 F.	0.22	24.43	**76.66**	24.75	0.39	37.27	31.22	71.90
	GPT-5	10.84	47.20	55.20	50.89	6.07	47.30	33.34	84.20
Ours	ViBridge-VQA (1.35%)	11.75	55.36	56.56	54.56	18.52	52.64	45.53	110.58
	ViBridge-VQA + LoRA (1.57%)	**14.67**	59.02	59.96	58.17	**22.53**	**56.25**	**49.32**	122.88

decoder LoRA (54.96 versus 54.78 validation F1), and with the same one-epoch LoRA it is 4.7 F1 higher (58.21 versus 53.47; Table 3).

Statistical stability. Our models are stable across seeds: on the test split, the standard deviation is at most 0.19 for F1 and 0.95 for CIDEr, and test F1 is at most 0.6 points below validation F1.

4.4 Choosing the Token Budget

Table 2 and Fig. 2a vary the number of global tokens $g \in \{8, 14\}$ and of local tokens $k \in \{1, 9, 36, 144\}$. Local tokens have by far the larger effect: at $g = 14$, going from 1 to 144 local tokens adds 4.9 F1 and 19.1 CIDEr on validation, whereas going from 8 to 14 global tokens adds only 0.2–0.6 F1 at a fixed k. Accuracy keeps increasing with k, but the gain per token falls from 0.07 F1 between 23 and 50 tokens to 0.015 between 50 and 158 tokens, so additional tokens bring diminishing returns.

Since accuracy grows with every added token, all configurations lie on the Pareto front of accuracy against tokens, and we select its knee (Section 3.5). On validation, the knee is $g = 14$, $k = 36$ for all eight metrics, whether cost is counted in visual tokens or in evaluation time on the T4, and TOPSIS with equal weights on accuracy and cost makes the same choice; the knee on the test split, computed only as a post-hoc check, is the same. This budget is a compromise rather than the most accurate configuration: $k = 144$ is 1.7 F1 higher, but the selected budget obtains 72% of its gain over the global-only model with 32% of its tokens.

Computational cost. ViBridge-VQA reduces the cost in two places. Its decoder reads 50 visual tokens, whereas the official tiling (at most six tiles plus a thumbnail)

Table 2: Effect of the token budget on the validation set (×100, mean ± std over three seeds; global only, $g = 8$: four seeds). Tokens: visual tokens passed to the decoder; Time: minutes to evaluate the validation and test questions on one Tesla T4. The selected budget is in bold.

g	k	Tokens	Time	BLEU	METEOR	ROUGE-L	CIDEr	F1
8	0	8	–	16.88 ±.23	41.38 ±.21	49.03 ±.12	99.07 ±.47	50.74 ±.17
14	0	14	–	16.81 ±.22	41.34 ±.23	48.91 ±.11	99.83 ±.53	50.67 ±.08
8	1	9	57.0	16.54 ±.27	41.37 ±.11	49.21 ±.13	99.27 ±.58	51.03 ±.12
8	9	17	59.2	17.58 ±.03	43.56 ±.20	50.96 ±.05	106.11 ±.55	52.82 ±.11
8	36	44	60.6	18.22 ±.39	45.31 ±.42	52.48 ±.43	111.88 ±1.43	54.32 ±.41
8	144	152	71.2	19.82 ±.00	47.51 ±.05	54.21 ±.06	119.05 ±.25	56.15 ±.08
14	1	15	58.8	17.30 ±.36	42.36 ±.19	49.93 ±.24	101.66 ±1.11	51.67 ±.25
14	9	23	57.7	17.83 ±.23	43.71 ±.13	51.17 ±.10	106.02 ±.80	52.98 ±.08
14	**36**	**50**	**60.0**	**18.73** ±.23	**46.01** ±.42	**53.10** ±.27	**113.29** ±1.01	**54.96** ±.28
14	144	158	70.2	20.18 ±.13	48.00 ±.05	54.70 ±.05	120.71 ±.12	56.61 ±.04

splits every AutoViVQA test image into seven views, i.e., 1,792 tokens. Its vision encoder processes one 336×336 view (577 tokens, about 191 GMACs) instead of seven 448×448 views (362 GMACs each), 13 times less computation. Within our own budgets, 144 local tokens instead of 36 make evaluation about 17% slower (Table 2).

4.5 Ablation Study

Where should the visual tokens come from? Table 3 compares three sources of visual tokens: the global `[CLS]` vector (a one-token *Residual* bridge or the *Multi-Token* bridge of Eq. (1)), a learned compression of the patches (*Tile-Attention* with eight learned queries, or a light or full Q-Former [12]), and our local tokens. Without decoder adaptation, the Multi-Token bridge is the best of these five, and the bridges that compress the patches are 3.7–5.6 F1 lower despite having up to 9.4× more parameters. Taking local tokens from the pre-trained projector instead works better: at the same $g = 8$, adding 36 or 144 of them improves F1 by 3.6 and 5.4 points (Table 2).

Local tokens and decoder adaptation are complementary. A decoder LoRA improves every global-only bridge and brings them within 0.8 F1 of one another (52.69–53.47). Even after this adaptation, all of them remain below ViBridge-VQA with a frozen decoder. Decoder adaptation is therefore not needed to surpass them, but it is still useful: in the same one-epoch joint training, it adds 3.3 F1 to ViBridge-VQA, more than the 2.7 F1 it adds to the Multi-Token bridge. Distilling the projector into the global-only bridge instead lowers F1 by 0.3–0.4 points.

Number of global tokens. We varied the Multi-Token bridge from $g = 4$ to $g = 20$ tokens (three seeds each). Validation F1 rose from 48.5 at $g = 4$ to 49.6 at $g = 8$ and 50.7 at $g = 14$, and stayed between 50.4 and 50.6 for $g = 16$–20.

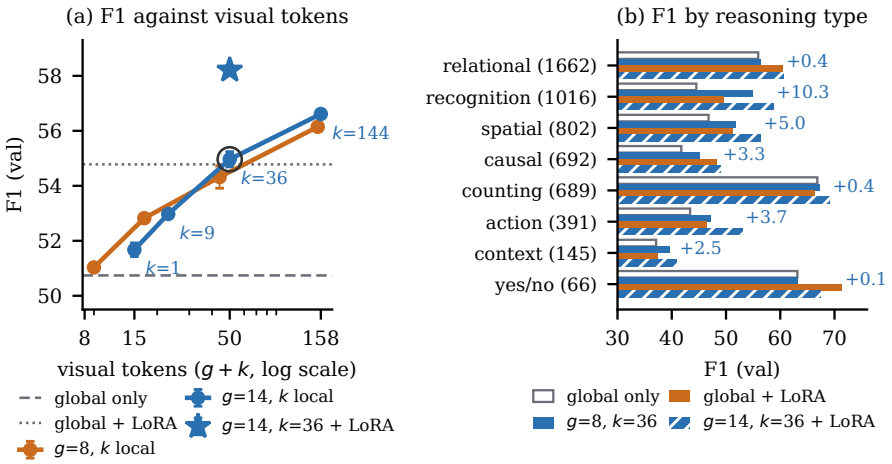


Fig. 2: (a) Validation F1 against the number of visual tokens (mean ± std over three seeds); the circled point is the knee, $g = 14$, $k = 36$. Horizontal lines: the global-only model (four seeds) and the same model with a three-epoch decoder LoRA (three seeds). (b) Validation F1 by reasoning type (number of questions in parentheses), each model averaged over all of its seeds; the numbers give the gain of adding 36 local tokens at the same $g = 8$. Global + LoRA: three-epoch decoder LoRA; $g = 14$, $k = 36$ + LoRA: ViBridge-VQA with a one-epoch decoder LoRA.

4.6 Analysis by Reasoning Type and Error Analysis

Reasoning types. Fig. 2b breaks the validation F1 down by reasoning type. Local tokens help most when the answer depends on what is visible in the image: at $g = 8$, adding 36 local tokens raises F1 by 10.3 on recognition, 5.0 on spatial and 3.7 on action questions, where this frozen-decoder model also outperforms the global-only model with LoRA. Decoder adaptation helps more on causal and relational questions, whose answers are the longest (5.0 and 5.6 words on average), and on yes/no questions. ViBridge-VQA with LoRA combines both strengths and is the best of the four models in seven of the eight categories, all except yes/no.

Error analysis. Our answers are as long as the references (4.3 words on average), and most of them (77–81%) partially overlap the closest reference. Compared with the global-only model, ViBridge-VQA raises the share of exact matches (F1 = 1) from 9.7% to 13.3% and lowers the share of answers with no word in common with any reference from 9.6% to 8.0% (6.8% with LoRA).

4.7 Generalisation to Other Datasets

Table 4 reports F1 on four Vietnamese VQA datasets that were not used for training: the scene-text datasets ViTextVQA [24] and OpenViVQA [22], and the

Table 3: Source of the visual tokens, without and with a decoder LoRA (validation, ×100, mean ± std over three seeds; Multi-Token: four seeds; *one seed). Params: trained bridge parameters. Best results per block are in bold.

Visual tokens from	Tokens	Params	BLEU	METEOR	ROUGE-L	CIDEr	F1
Bridge only (two epochs)							
Residual	1	4.86M	12.98 ±.15	36.86 ±.31	44.23 ±.38	86.48 ±.77	46.02 ±.36
Multi-Token	8	7.35M	16.88 ±.23	41.38 ±.21	49.03 ±.12	99.07 ±.47	50.74 ±.17
Tile-Attention	8	4.14M	12.34 ±.32	36.11 ±.73	43.28 ±.95	84.14 ±1.40	45.14 ±.92
Light Q-Former	8	27.6M	13.99 ±.33	37.57 ±.60	45.37 ±.63	88.07 ±1.89	47.06 ±.66
Full Q-Former	16	69.4M	13.76 ±.36	37.43 ±.34	45.10 ±.41	87.74 ±1.24	46.84 ±.47
ViBridge-VQA (k=36)	50	12.86M	18.73 ±.23	46.01 ±.42	53.10 ±.27	113.29 ±1.01	54.96 ±.28
ViBridge-VQA (k=144)	158	12.86M	**20.18** ±.13	**48.00** ±.05	**54.70** ±.05	**120.71** ±.12	**56.61** ±.04
+ decoder LoRA (one joint epoch, 2.16M parameters)							
Residual	1	4.86M	18.94 ±.36	43.33 ±.33	51.04 ±.13	104.25 ±.93	52.69 ±.14
Multi-Token	8	7.35M	19.72 ±.09	44.11 ±.23	51.79 ±.15	106.68 ±.69	53.47 ±.17
Tile-Attention*	8	4.14M	19.13	43.44	51.25	104.72	52.82
Light Q-Former	8	27.6M	19.92 ±.31	43.77 ±.19	51.54 ±.13	106.26 ±.73	53.21 ±.14
Full Q-Former	16	69.4M	19.57 ±.25	43.96 ±.21	51.62 ±.30	106.50 ±1.04	53.29 ±.29
ViBridge-VQA (k=36)	50	12.86M	**22.27** ±.17	**49.55** ±.06	**56.42** ±.14	**124.88** ±.75	**58.21** ±.16

Table 4: F1 on Vietnamese VQA datasets not used for training (×100; mean ± std over three random samples of about 1,000 test questions; our models: seed 42). Best results are in bold.

Model	ViTextVQA	OpenViVQA	ViVQA-X	ViVQA	Avg.
Vintern-1B, zero-shot	32.01 ±.31	**58.40** ±.80	14.52 ±.47	23.90 ±.24	32.21
Global only + LoRA	3.96 ±.09	21.56 ±.48	15.89 ±.65	31.48 ±1.15	18.22
ViBridge-VQA	15.14 ±.47	28.24 ±.79	24.91 ±.14	42.68 ±1.52	27.74
ViBridge-VQA, $k = 144$	**33.26** ±.67	35.89 ±.80	**27.89** ±.13	**44.95** ±.90	**35.50**
ViBridge-VQA + LoRA	15.39 ±.39	28.99 ±.51	27.64 ±.11	44.76 ±1.21	29.20

general-domain ViVQA-X [8] and ViVQA [30]. Local tokens bring the largest gains on scene text, where the global-only model largely fails: on ViTextVQA, 144 local tokens raise F1 from 3.96 to 33.26, on par with the zero-shot Vintern-1B, which reads up to seven 448 × 448 views instead of one 336 × 336 view. On the general-domain datasets, ViBridge-VQA outperforms both reference models, and the decoder LoRA brings the 36-token model close to the 144-token one. Averaged over the four datasets, ViBridge-VQA with 144 local tokens obtains the highest F1.

4.8 Qualitative Analysis

Fig. 3 illustrates how the two components work together. In every example, ViBridge-VQA already identifies the relevant content of the image (the driver's phone, the helmets, the football match, the bird feeder), but its answer remains vague. Adding the decoder LoRA turns it into the precise answer, for instance that the driver is using *the phone* and that the helmets are worn *to protect their*



Fig. 3: Qualitative examples from the AutoViVQA validation set (seed 42). Q: question, GT: one of the five reference answers; Ours: ViBridge-VQA ($g = 14$, $k = 36$), Ours+LoRA: ViBridge-VQA with a one-epoch decoder LoRA.

heads, in line with the gains of decoder adaptation on causal and yes/no questions (Section 4.6).

5 Conclusion

In this work, we introduced **ViBridge-VQA**, a parameter-efficient approach that improves the Vietnamese VLM Vintern-1B for generative VQA without updating any of its pre-trained weights, by giving its frozen decoder trainable global tokens from the `[CLS]` vector and local tokens from the pre-trained projector. With 14 global and 36 local tokens, the knee of the accuracy–cost Pareto front on validation, training only the bridge raises F1 on AutoViVQA from 17.6 to 54.6, comparable to the published F1 of the fine-tuned Vintern-1B, and training a lightweight decoder LoRA with it raises F1 to 58.2. Adding local tokens improves F1 far more than increasing the global tokens from 8 to 14, and they complement decoder adaptation.

The task-specific ViMoE-VQA still reaches a higher F1, and accuracy had not saturated at the 144 local tokens available at our resolution.

Overall, an existing Vietnamese VLM can be improved substantially by choosing which visual tokens its frozen decoder receives, and how many, with an explicit accuracy–cost criterion. The code and the image-disjoint split are available at `https://github.com/nguyennn263/modular-vlm-finetune`.

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